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*Supporting narrated video (NV) demonstrations, high-speed video (HSV) clips, technical proofs (TP), and all past articles are available online at **drdavepoolinfo.com**. Reference numbers used in the articles help you locate the resources on the website.*

Have you ever heard the saying: “Draw for show. Follow for dough?” It refers to the fact that it is much easier to predict and control cue ball (CB) direction and travel distance with follow shots. This enables precise position play, scratch avoidance, and lock-up safeties. To be able to execute all a wide range of follow shots accurately and with confidence, it helps to know some basic principles. It also helps to practice follow-control drills. Below, I’ll summarize useful advice pertaining to these things from a recent online video (**NV L.83**). The focus is on nearly straight follow shots.

Probably the best advice for follow shot control is to use a high tip and vary your stroke length based on the desired follow distance. If you use a consistent, smoothly accelerating stroke, shot speed is directly related to stroke length. With normal shots, every 1/8 of my stroke gives about a diamond of follow distance (see **Image 1**). This will obviously depend on the player and table conditions, but it works well for me on most equipment. Try the drill shown in the video if you want to find out how well this works for you. An 1/8 stroke length should send the CB forward about 1 diamond. A 2/8 or 1/4 stroke should send the CB forward about two diamonds. As shown in the video, try every 1/8 up to a full stroke, using the same smoothly accelerating stroke for each shot. Note that with the CB close to object ball (OB), and with fast shot speed, a high tip position is required to guarantee full topspin roll at the OB.

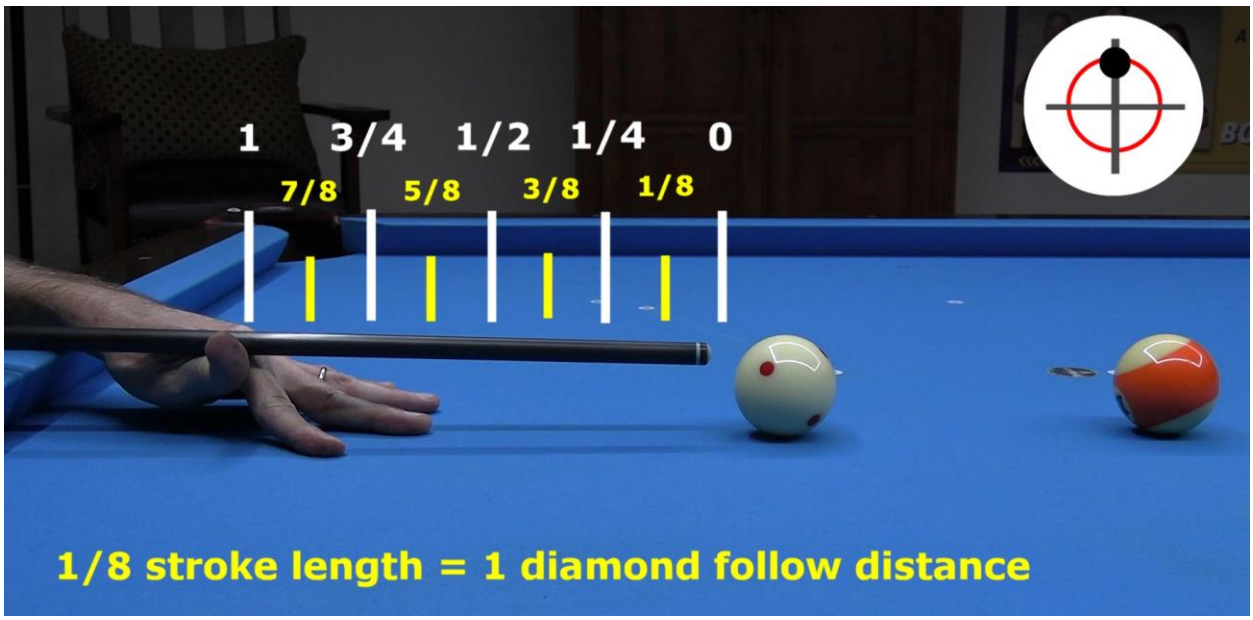

Image 1 Stroke fractions

A useful follow reference is knowing how far the OB will travel as a factor of a given CB follow distance. With a full hit and typical ball conditions, the OB travels about 7.5-times as far as a rolling CB. **Image 2** shows a good test shot to try on your table to see how close the balls get to the 7.5x factor. With the OB starting 7 diamonds from the head rail, if the CB follows forward 1 diamond with full topspin roll, the OB should just barely bounce off the head cushion.

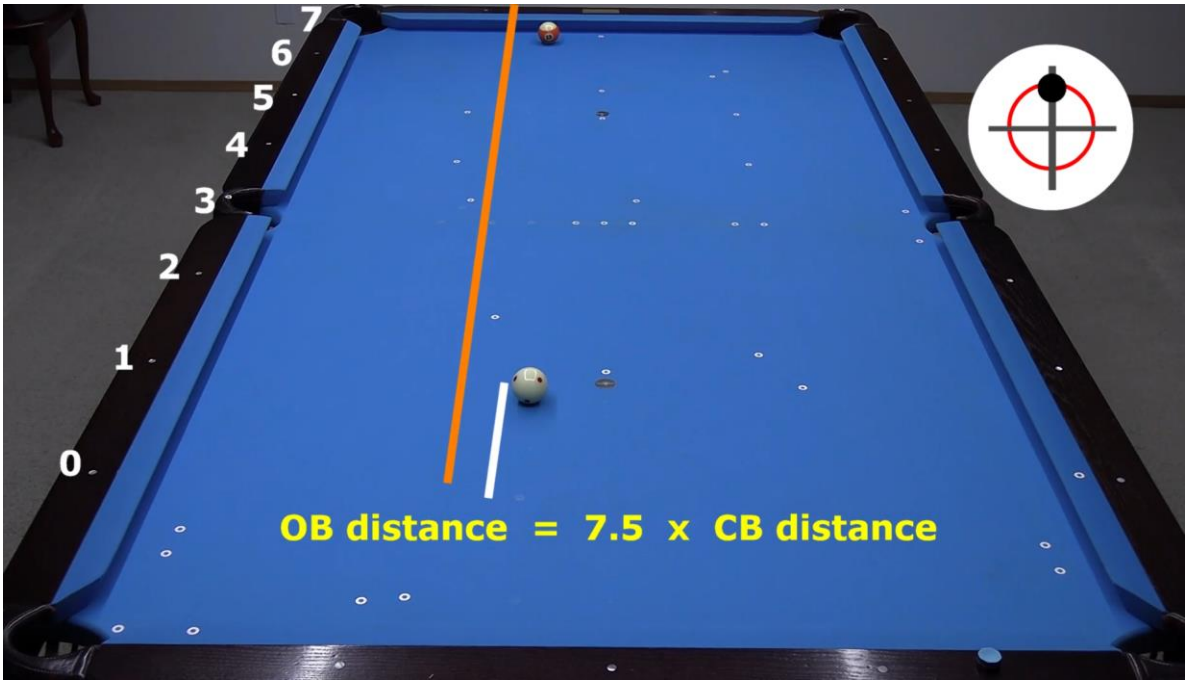

Image 2 **CB-OB follow ratio**

As shown in online super-slow-motion video **HSV B.15**, when a rolling ball hits a cushion straight on, it loses about half its speed. When ½ the speed is lost, the ball will travel only ¼ of the distance it would have if the table were longer with no cushion. The ½ and ¼ factors obviously depend some on rail and cushion properties. For example, the numbers would be smaller on a bouncy Diamond-brand table. With a little simple math, you can use the 7.5x factor to predict OB travel distance even when the OB bounces off a cushion. For example (see **Image 3**), with a ½ (4/8) stroke, the CB travels forward 4 diamonds. 7.5-times that is 30. 6 diamonds to the cushion leaves 24, and ¼ of that is 6, so the OB travels 6 diamonds off the cushion.

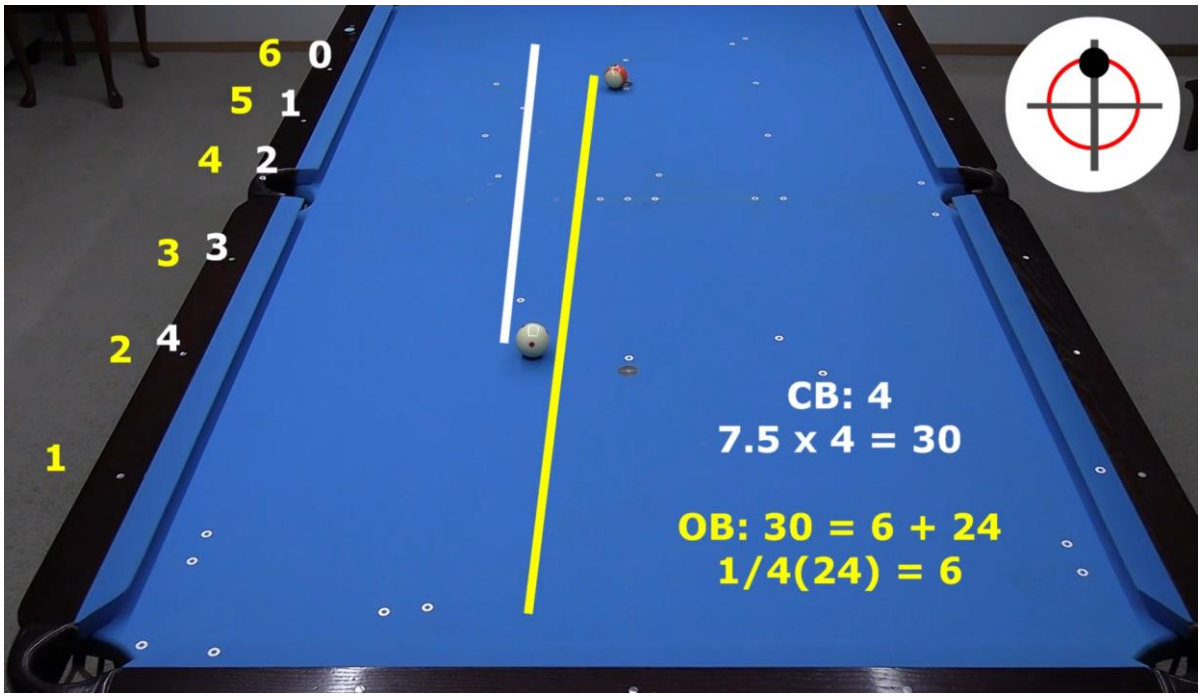

Image 3 **Rebound distance off cushion**

Another useful reference is the OB distance from the rail where a rolling CB follows forward to the end rail and banks the OB straight back to the other end rail (see **Image 4**). As shown in recent online video **NV L.82**, this is a useful reference in the game of one-pocket. But it is also a good way to compare tables to get a feel for the bounciness of the cushions. It also offers a good speed-control practice drill. As demonstrated in online video **NV L.83**, if the OB is too far from the rail, the OB makes it to the rail, but the CB does not. And if the OB is too close to the rail, the CB makes it to the rail, but the OB does not. Again, there is a precise distance for every table (see the "reference line" in Image 4), where both balls barely get to the end rails with the right speed. It is a fun and useful exercise to find both the distance and shot speed required to do this.

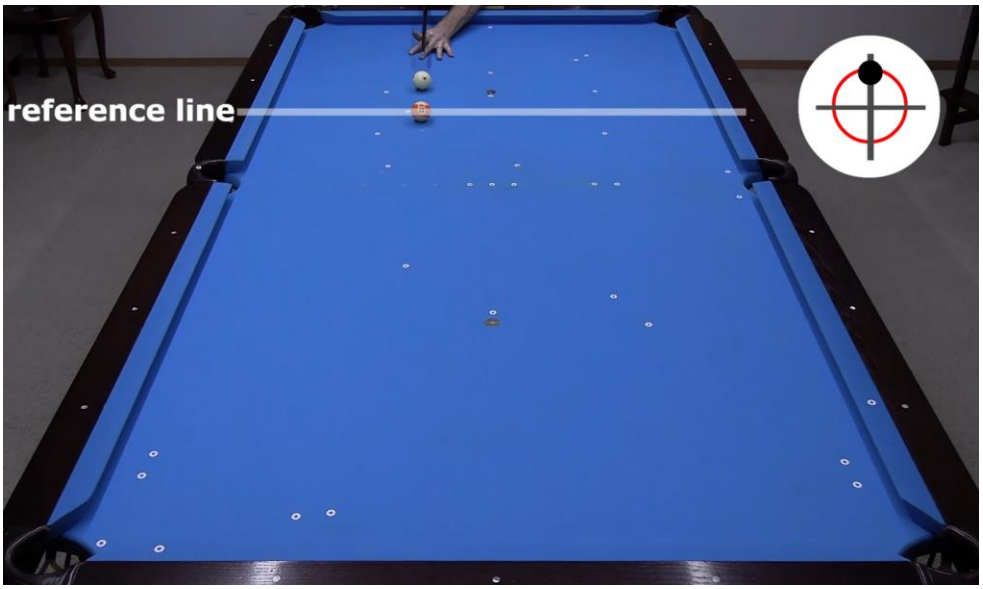

Image 4 Follow speed reference

Be sure to watch online video **NV L.83** to see everything demonstrated. Also try out everything the next time you are at a table. Being able to "follow for the dough" with confidence can help you win many games and matches.

Good luck with your game,
Dr. Dave

normal video

NV L.82 – Straight-Back Bank SPEED REFERENCE Useful for All Pool Games
NV L.83 – FOLLOW SHOT CONTROL Principles and Drills

high speed video

HSV B.15 – straight-on kick shot rebound losses and spin changes for roll, stun, and draw shots

PS:

- I know other authors and I tend to use lots of terminology, and I know not all readers are totally familiar with these terms. If you ever come across a word or phrase you do not fully understand, please refer to the online glossary at ***drdavepoolinfo.com***.

Dr. Dave is a PBIA Master Instructor, Dean of the Billiard University, and author of the book: The Illustrated Principles of Pool and Billiards and numerous instructional DVD series, all available at: ***DrDaveBilliards.com***.